Book Review Report
Book Title - "More Than Meets the Eye: Essays on Bangladeshi Politics"
Bibliographic Information
Author: Ali Riaz
Publisher: University Press Limited (UPL), Dhaka
Year of Publication: 2022
Pages: 238
ISBN: 9789845063777

1. Introduction :

The process of political development in Bangladesh since independence is very complex. The political trajectory consists of general election histories , institutional and civilian force and amendments of the constitution. The book has given a concise analytical insight through some thoughtful essays . Mr Riaz critically analyzed that the inner dynamics of politics in Bangladesh were influential over political institutions, religious institutes, civil- military relationship, democratic status and governance system. Mr Riaz depicted that numerous political reality keep hidden which can be understood only by analyzing historical and institutional trend of the last few decades. Bangladeshi politics took a massive shift and peoples of Bangladesh experienced gradual deviation of democracy as political actors initiated a new type of political settlement where democracy and people's right were tertiary consideration . The book gradually analyzed the political events and political movements unearthing the reasons underlies behind and provides projection for upcoming days .

2. Body

2.1 Overview of the contents :

The book is a collection of essays regarding the issues that influence politics for the last few decades . The institutional strength and the governance system determines the political outcome. The book focuses on independent judiciary, competitiveness in election, unbiased amendments of the constitution , professionalism of civil service and civil-military relations .Erosion of democracy is caused by controlled political competitiveness, fragile accountability, poor autonomy of organizations, miss-trust of people over democratic institutions and electoral system.
Mr Ali Riaz explained that historically religion is an influential force in politics and playing a pivotal role in influencing politics .

Another point is the relationship of public institutions with political parties and reasons for lack of political dialogue is too much political division.

2.2 Analysis of main theme:

The writers argued that strength of democratic institutions is important than election and electoral processes cannot ensure proper governance unless people's trust is gained, accountability and transparency is maintained, the role of law is established in every wake of citizens' life .The writer argued that the authoritarian perspective in democracy cannot be eradicated only by the democratic constitution where regulatory institutes become marginalized. The robust democratic institutions can establish people's rights and people can enjoy unobstructed constitutional rights in democratic environment. The role of independent judiciary is essential for democratic rights.

2.3 Critical evaluation:

Analytical insight and critical perspective of the book is profound , rigorous and thought-provoking . Writer has brought out the reasons behind and the causes underlies the political events by extensive digging of the amendments of constitution, exhaustive and comprehensive investigation of politics and the sequences of political history of Bangladesh. After reading the book, the readers get a strong reasoning behind current political system of Bangladesh, not only just go through the historic events of political system. The writer has compared Bangladeshi democracy with the democracies of advanced world and illustrated that challenges referred to governance are common in different countries in the different corners of the world. The perspective of comparison and contrast with different other democratic countries of the world truly enhance value and appreciation of the book and make it relevant , pertinent and expedient .

The usage of standard English language in the book made it readable to both normal people and expert professional and researchers . The writer presented the complex political concepts and philosophical topics in easy and readable way for the professionals and intellectuals as well as common ordinary readers. The writer describes the complex political theory assertions with pragmatic political illustrations and accordingly the book is recommended for the students, civil servants, academicians , researchers and policymakers. The writer smartly avoided emotionally biased arguments and controversial issues, rather he drew unbiased and neutral conclusion. To describe sensational political matter, unbiased, impassionate and neutral approaches truly attract the readers and won their heart, moreover it gives the scope to get the transparent image of the book. The writer described that institutional governance strongly depends on the adherence, compliance and honor to the spirit of the constitution and professional, efficient, transparent and accountable state administration and state machineries and after all gaining trust and

confidence of peoples of the country .Accordingly the book is relevant to the public servants, political activists , civil society, policy makers and even for the young learners .

2.4 Relevance to public administration:

The civil servants deliver service to the people under political environment. So understanding the hidden complexities of political dynamics are relevant for them .
Mr Riaz focuses on capacity building of the public institutions and the public servants , gaining trust and confidence, establishing the rule of law. Professional civil servants and institutional strength are crucial for stability and democracy. The civil servants are responsible to maintain stability at the time of transition and crises . The book emphasizes the importance for transparency and accountability, fair judiciary and environment of justice and fairness, dynamic and capable political leaders, strong and robust institutions, and unbiased, neutral , professional and trained civil servants and after all gaining trust and confidence of people by delivering public service.

2.5 Limitations of the book:
Instead of numerous strength, the book faces few limitations. The book focuses on governance and political institutions and providing low focus on technology transformation, economic upliftment, marginalized capacity of local government.
Moreover there are some overlapping issues on the essays. The book repeats the issues such as democratic institutions, constitutional amendments ,political polarization in the essays .
Moreover the writer identifies some shortcomings and challenges of governance but didn't recommend any pragmatic suggestions to overcome those. Whatever the limitations do not degrade the overall value of the book, rather still it have huge appeal.

2.6 Personal reflection:
Reading the book my critical reasoning on complex political dynamics enhanced and the underlying issues on political shifts revealed . I have learnt that visible activities like holding election , change of government, political demonstrations, electoral campaigns are not the only the political mechanism ,there are many hidden underlying games.. The crucial issues are constitutional and institutional capacity, the freedom of constitutional bodies, confidence and trust of common people and well trained efficient and professional public servants. I have got an clear understanding of the complex political phenomena and different political dynamics from this book. They book has depicted the mysterious and complex political landscape of Bangladeshi clearly .

3. Conclusion:

The book is a precious collection of essays of Mr Ali Riaz who is a famous political scientist and scholar. Readers get thorough understanding of historic constitutional institutions which determine Bangladeshi politics. The analysis of the book is neutral and the language is comfortable for both professionals and common readers. Mr Ali Riaz focuses on democratic institutions, constitutional amendments, laws of the land, public confidence rather than concentrating on political figures in isolate manner. The book successfully connects historic incidents with institutional governance difficulties and challenges. Even though some limitations exists , still its having huge significance and immense values. This book can be a robust resource for public servants, policy makers, researchers and young learners . The book contains thoughtful essays on governance, institutional capacity building, democratic transparency and accountability, ethical and moral values of civil servants . Young leaders and learners may carefully read this book in depth for understanding v democratic challenges, good governance , democratic good practices in Bangladesh. The book clearly depicted the complex political landscape of Bangladesh along with the hidden dynamics and factors that underlies out of peoples' sight .

4. References: (Harvard style)

1. Main Reference (The Book Itself)

Riaz, A. (2022) More than meets the eye: essays on Bangladeshi politics. Dhaka: The University Press Limited (UPL).

2-10. Supporting References:

2. On Political Settlement Theory (Core argument of Ali Riaz's book)

Khan, M. (2010) Political settlements and the governance of growth-enhancing institutions. London: SOAS, University of London.

3. On Bangladesh's Democratic Backsliding

Riaz, A. (2019) Voting in a hybrid regime: explaining the 2018 Bangladeshi election. Singapore: Palgrave Macmillan.

4. On Authoritarianism in Bangladesh

Lewis, D. (2011) Bangladesh: politics, economy and civil society. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

5. On History of Bangladeshi Politics

Jahan, R. (2015) Political parties in Bangladesh: challenges of democratization. Dhaka: Prothoma Prokashan.

6. On Competitive Authoritarianism Framework (Useful for theoretical discussion)

Levitsky, S. and Way, L.A. (2010) Competitive authoritarianism: hybrid regimes after the Cold War. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

7. On State and Bureaucracy-Military Nexus

Siddiqui, K. (2005) 'State, politics and bureaucracy in Bangladesh', South Asian Journal, 8, pp. 1-15.

8. On Elections and Legitimacy

Riaz, A. (2023) 'The pathway of democratic backsliding in Bangladesh', Democratization, 30(2), pp. 215-234.

9. On Civil Society and Governance

Lewis, D. and Hossain, A. (2022) 'The political economy of Bangladesh's contested development', Journal of Contemporary Asia, 52(4), pp. 536-556.

10. International Report for Data/Evidence

Freedom House (2022) Freedom in the World 2022: Bangladesh. Washington, DC: Freedom House.